

**India Moving: A History of
Migration**

Dreams and Diaspora

Nandhini Somasundaram

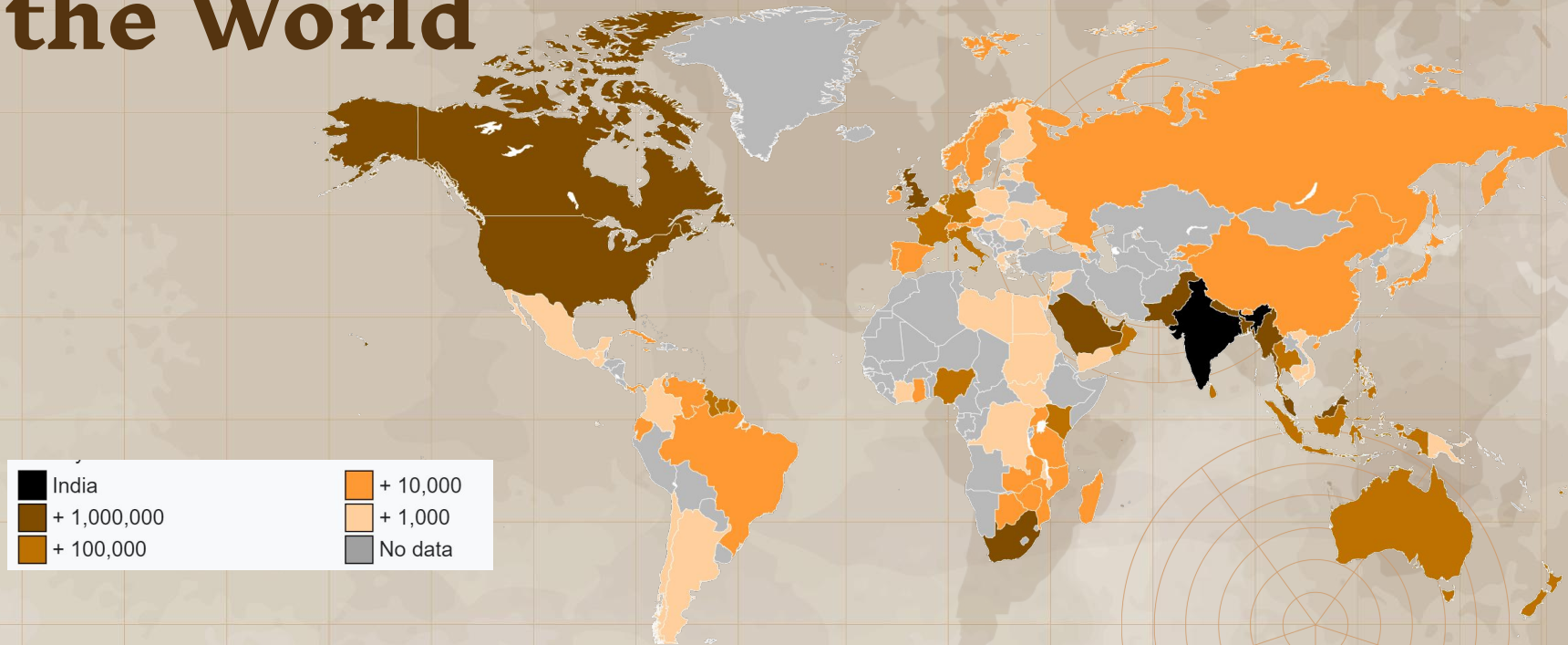


What is diaspora?

Using the definition of the Report of the High Level Committee on the Indian Diaspora, we define the term as such “The report used the word to refer to NRI citizens and People of Indian Origin (PIO) who did not hold Indian citizenship but were linked to the country up to four generations, or by marriage, with caveats on the countries of destination.”



Map of the Indian Diaspora in the World



By Alice Hunter - Empty map: File:World map (Miller cylindrical projection, blank).svg Information available on page Indian people and Non-resident Indian and person of Indian origin on the English Wikipedia Number of Indians living abroad per country: NW, 1615 L. St. Pew Research Center's Global Attitudes Project Global Migration Map: Origins and Destinations, 1990-2017 (in en-US)., CC BY-SA 4.0, <https://commons.wikimedia.org/w/index.php?curid=101164007>

Brief Introduction

Evolution of Indian Diaspora in Numbers

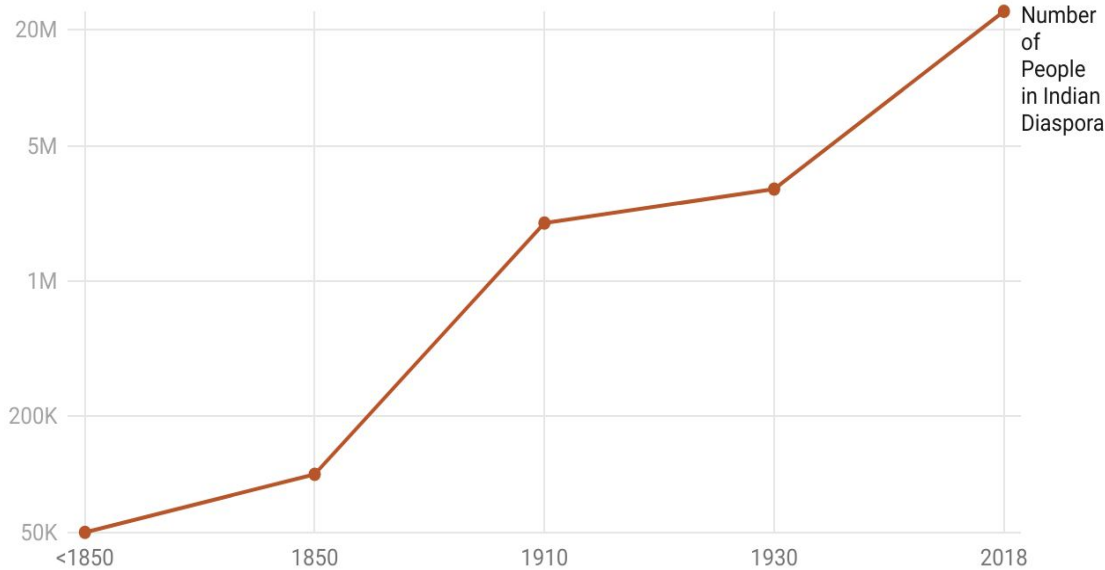


Chart: Nandhini Somasundaram • Source: Moving India: A History of Migration • Created with Datawrapper

Distribution of Indian Diaspora by Region in 1910

Asia Latin America and the Caribbean Islands Other

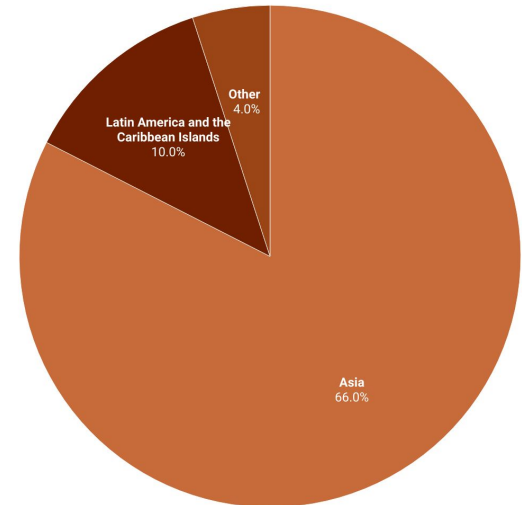


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The background of the slide features a stylized, sepia-toned map of the Pacific Ocean. A grid of latitude and longitude lines is overlaid on the map. Concentric circles are drawn around a point in the central Pacific, resembling a radar or a map projection. The landmasses of North America, South America, and Australia are visible in a darker shade of brown.

Sweet Dreams and Nightmares: The Sugar Plantations

“If the legend of the *kaalapani* promised the loss of caste upon return, this was precisely what the lower castes wanted and served to prompt them to experiment with overseas migration”

Destinations for Indian Migrants



Migrants and Sugar Plantations

- Mostly moved for indentured labour.
- Most migrants did not return to India after, and settled in their destination region.
- A lot migrants moved to escape caste system, but were faced with racial discrimination.

Number of Indian Migrants by Destination Region

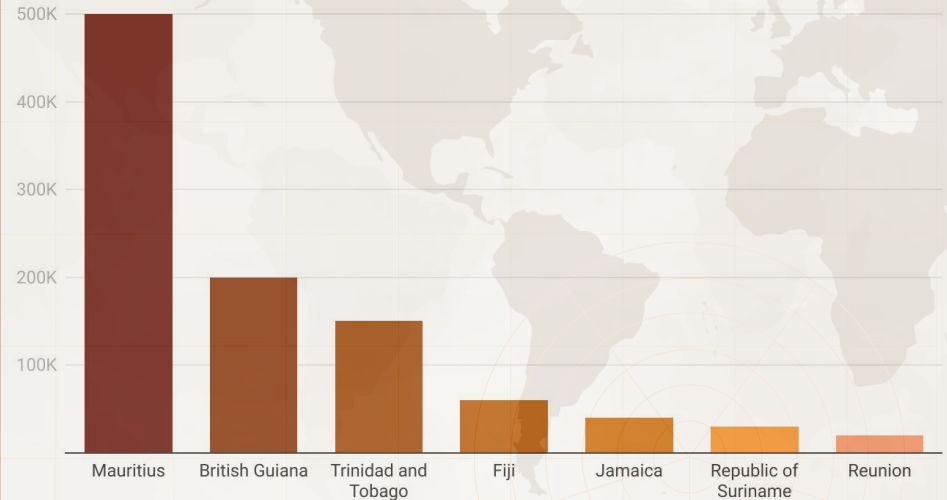
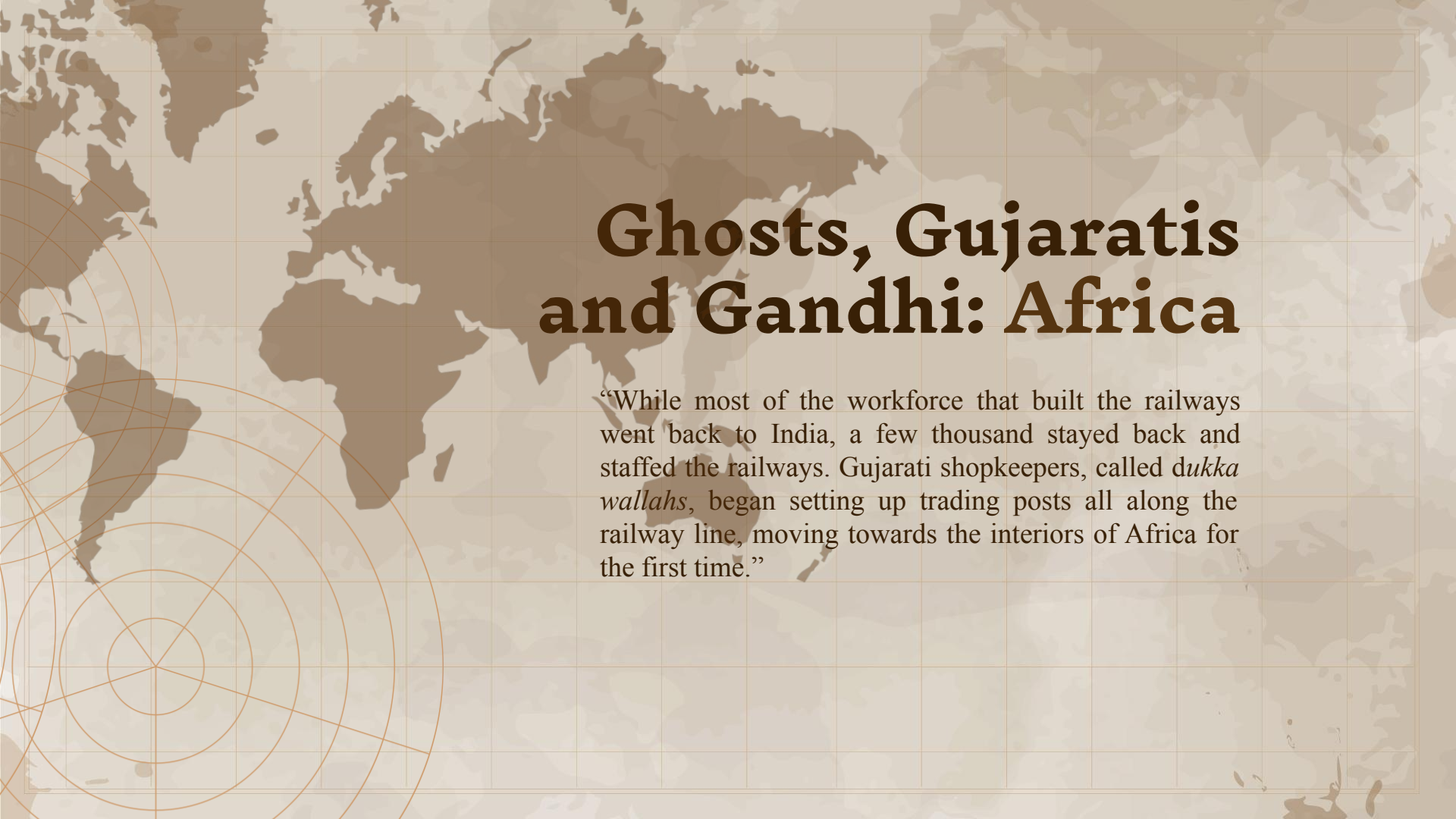


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Ghosts, Gujaratis and Gandhi: Africa

“While most of the workforce that built the railways went back to India, a few thousand stayed back and staffed the railways. Gujarati shopkeepers, called *dukka wallahs*, began setting up trading posts all along the railway line, moving towards the interiors of Africa for the first time.”

East Africa



- Indian migrants went to work on the Uganda Railways
- Few thousands workers stayed back after completion.
- Most migrants either managed shops or worked in the railways.
- Slowly, large number of people from service sector also moved in.
- Currently, around 200,000 people of Indian origin live in East Africa.

South Africa

- From 1860, 150,000 workers were brought to Natal from India
- There was widespread dislike for nascent middle class Indian by white South Africans
- Political organizations and political movement
- Present day, Indians still make up 2% of South Africa's population
- 10% of KwaZulu-Natal's population



Founders of the Natal Indian Congress.

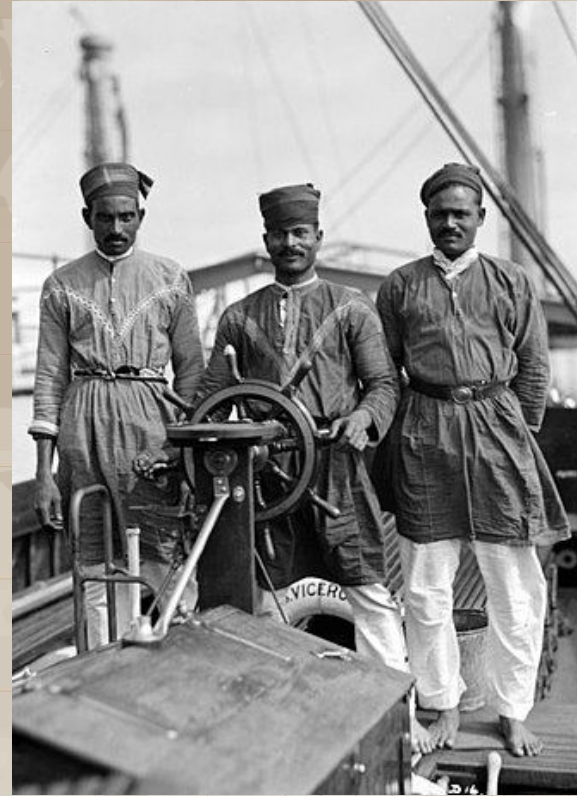


Ponte all'Indiano: Bridging Europe and India

“Cricket itself became a litmus test of loyalty. The Tebbit test, named after Lord Tebbit, proposed that Indians could be considered to have successfully assimilated into British society only if they rooted for England during cricket matches against India. ”

Mapping the Presence

- Since 1690, ships were moving from India to England.
- First migrants were lascars and ayahs
- Later, students, artists, jugglers etc joined
- Dadabhai Naoroji became first Indian member of British Parliament in 1890
- World Wars also brought Indians to England
- By the early 1900s, the number of Indians in Britain started growing to tens of thousands.



*Three lascar crew of the P&O liner
RMS Viceroy of India*

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Lascar>

Post-Independence Presence



Map of the UK's highways

- Higher wages and partition-related communal violence motivated migration to England
- Punjabis from districts linked with the Great Indian Migration Wave predominantly migrated
- East African-Indian migrants, primarily Gujarati traders, emerged in the late '60s and early '70s
- Over three-fourths of the Indian diaspora settled along the M1 and M6 highways, connecting London, Leicester, Coventry, Birmingham, Manchester, Leeds, and Bradford

Number of Indian Migrants by Region in Europe

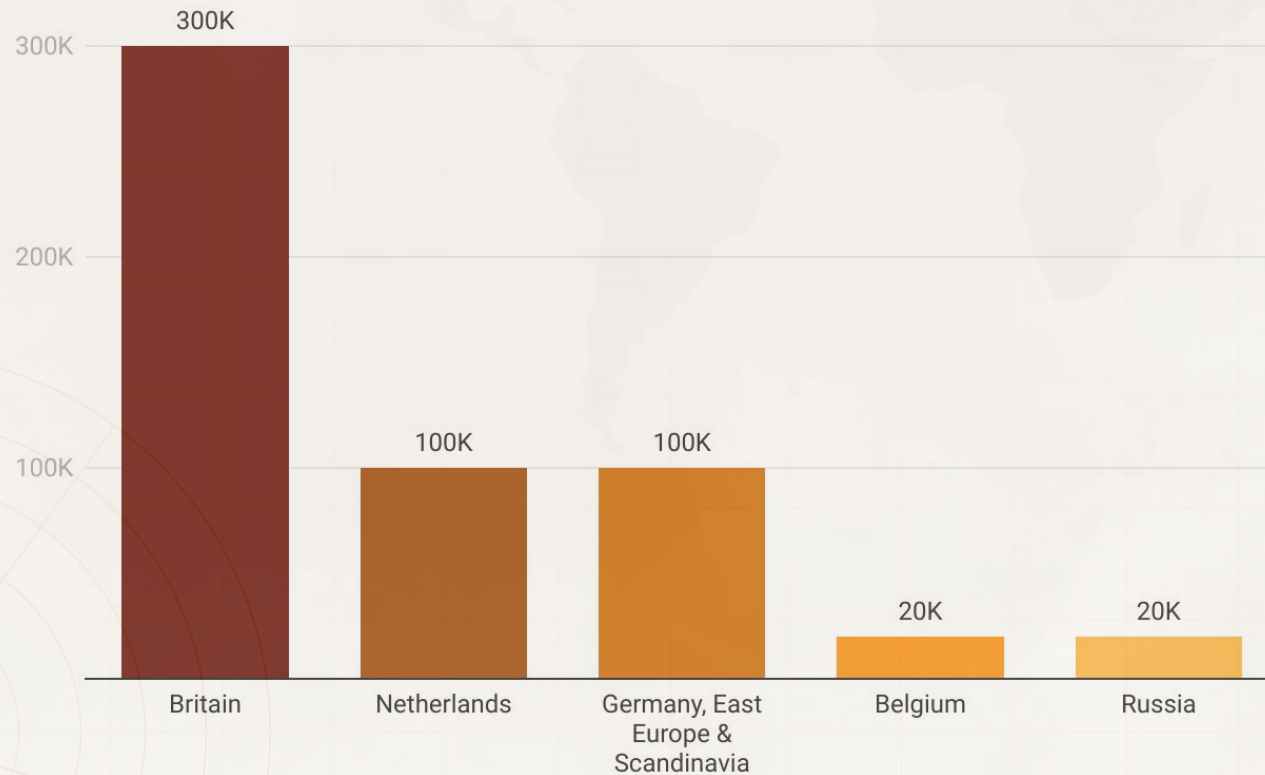


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Rest of Europe and India

- France, Portuguese has presence of Indian diaspora due to colonial ties
- Indian diaspora in France is mostly Tamil
- Indian diaspora in Portuguese is a combination of Goans and 'twice migrants' from Africa-Angola & Mozambique.
- Spain's Indian diaspora is dominated by Sindhis
- Italy has attracted recent migrants in the past 3 decades
- Dominated by Punjabi Sikhs and followed by Roman-Catholic Keralites

Indian Diaspora in France, Portugal and Spain

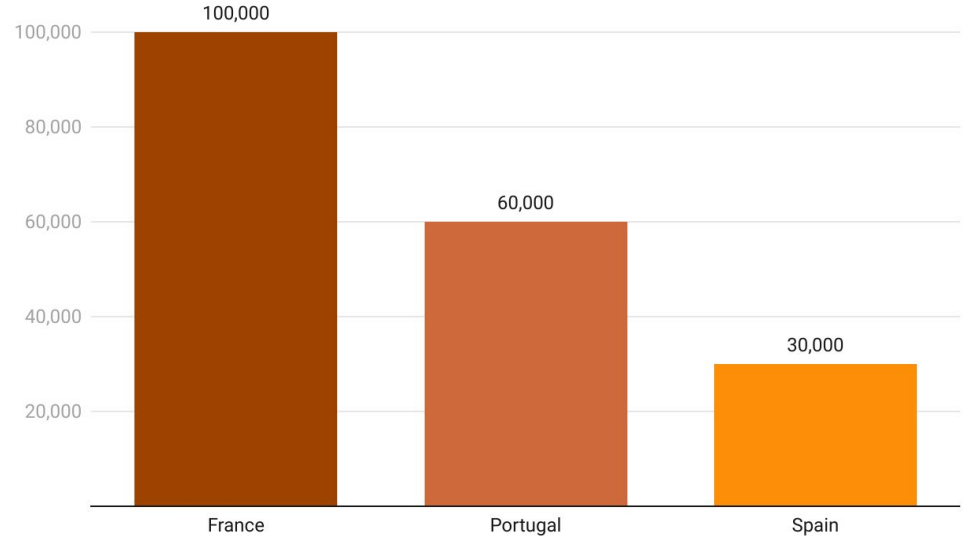
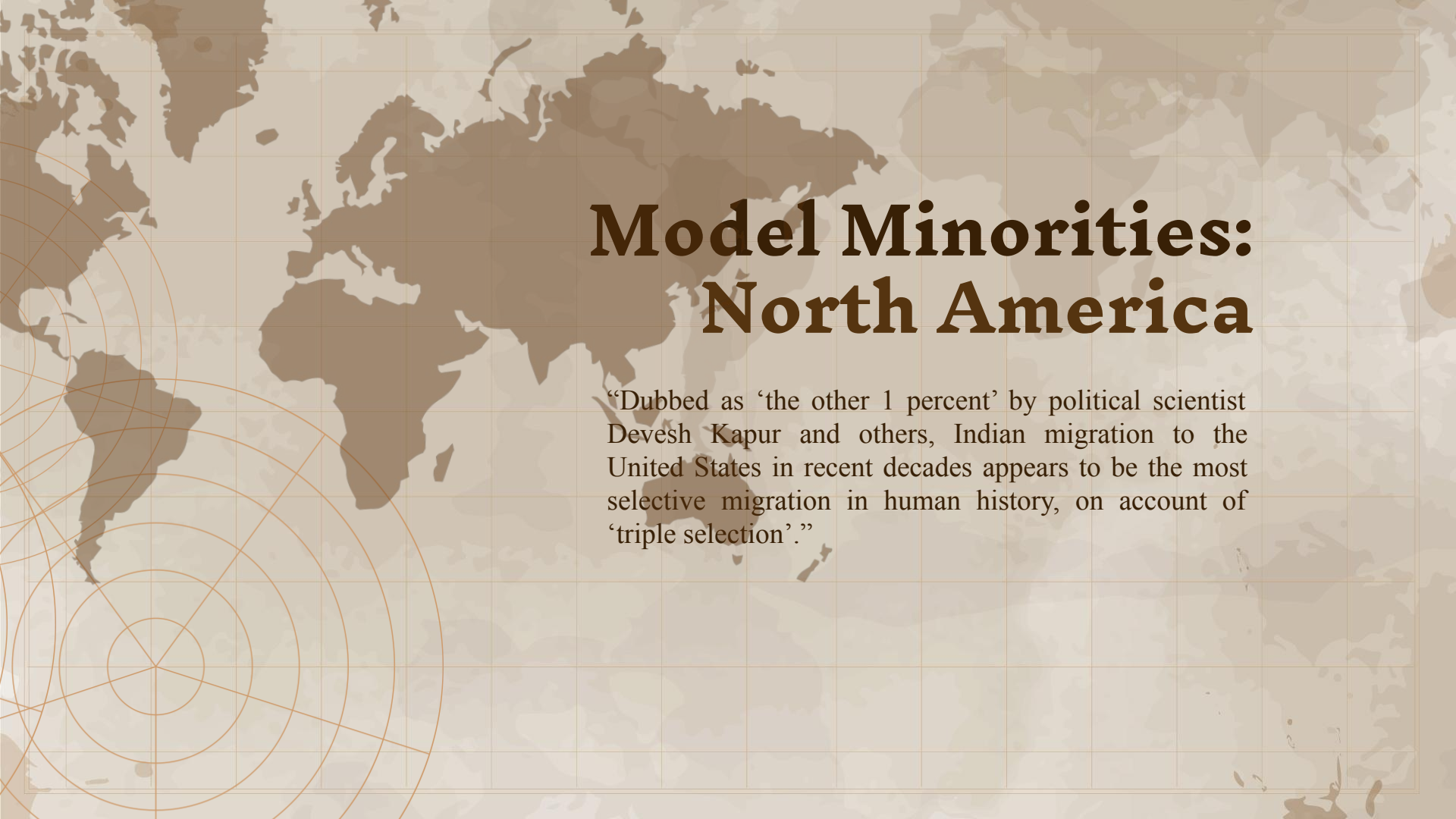


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Model Minorities: North America

“Dubbed as ‘the other 1 percent’ by political scientist Devesh Kapur and others, Indian migration to the United States in recent decades appears to be the most selective migration in human history, on account of ‘triple selection’.”

Migrant Links between US and India

- First established in 19th century when sailors landed on American soil.
- More systematic migration in early 20th century- Punjabi Sikhs.
- Student migration also took place in late 19th century.
- Indians faced a lot strict immigration laws from 1910 for almost 5 decades due to discrimination.
- Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 opened the doors once again but this time towards skilled migrants.



Anandibai Joshee, the first known Indian woman to receive an educational degree in the US

Migration after 1950

- Gujaratis and Punjabis dominated earlier migration.
- South Indians dominated latter migration, especially Tamilians and Teulugus.
- Districts like Anand in Gujarat and Guntur in Andhra Pradesh became major sites of American emigration
- Bengaluru and Hyderabad forged close connections with American NRIs for entrepreneurial ventures and investments in real estate.

Present
Day

Huge IT Migration

Huge waves of IT migration clustered around New York–New Jersey cluster, Silicon Valley or San Francisco Bay area, Washington D.C., Chicago, Houston and Dallas.

1995

Family Reunification

This was followed by a wave of family reunification where spouses and children joined the early migrants.

1965-70

Highly Educated Indians Migrated

Mostly from IITs to science, engineering and medical fields.

Features of American Born Confused Desis (ABCDs)

- Indian-origin community in America is diverse in language, class, and religion, but less so in caste.
- Politically, they lean towards the Democratic Party.
- They engage in diverse occupations, including entrepreneurship.
- Over 3 million Indian-origin individuals reside in the USA, forming 1% of the population.
- Despite success stories, thousands of poor and undocumented Indian workers exist, often overlooked.

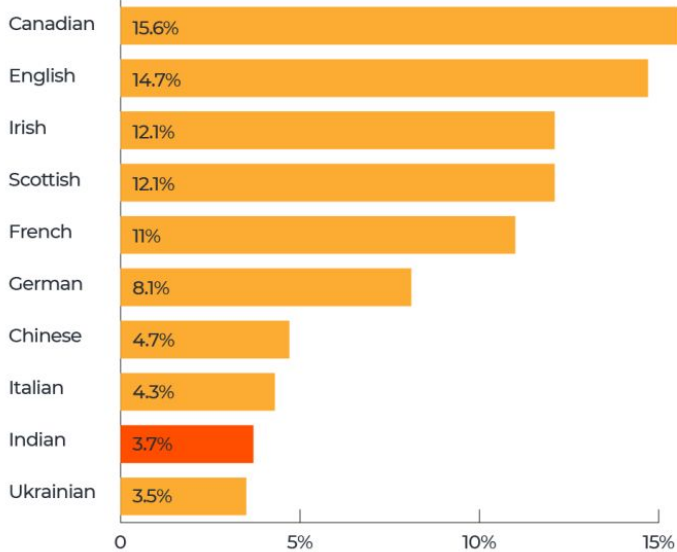
India and Canada

DEMOGRAPHICS

Canada's Indian population

Canada is home to nearly 1.4 million people of Indian origin, making up roughly 3.7 percent of the country's total population of 37 million.

Canada's 10 largest self-reported ethnic groups:



Source: Statistics Canada | 2021

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- Indians in Canada represent 4% of the total population.
- Mostly reside in Toronto in the east and Vancouver in the west.
- Most migrants belong to a few districts of eastern Punjab that belong to the Great Indian Migration Wave.
- Indians faced restrictive immigrant laws till 1950s and only 3000 Indians were in Canada then.
- Currently, similar to America, immigration has been dominated by highly skilled workers



Oil and Toil: West Asia

“The Gulf states have consistently followed a policy of ‘separation’ rather than ‘assimilation’. Yet, the vast wage differential between India and the Gulf, as it is called in Kerala, is attractive enough for migrants to consider the option at least once in their lives”

Indians Migrants and the Gulf

- Immigrants comprise 50% of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries
- Over seven million Indians work in the Gulf states,
- This is currently 1/4th of the Indian diaspora and 1/2 of India's current emigrant stock.
- Citizenship laws based on paternal jus sanguinis (right of blood) rule out permanent settlement and automatically create circulatory migration
- The state of Kerala is an important labour pipeline to the Gulf Countries



Mapping Migratory History

1950

Over 6000 Indians were employed by oil companies in the Persian Gulf.

1970s

The number of employed Indians rose steadily to 40,000.

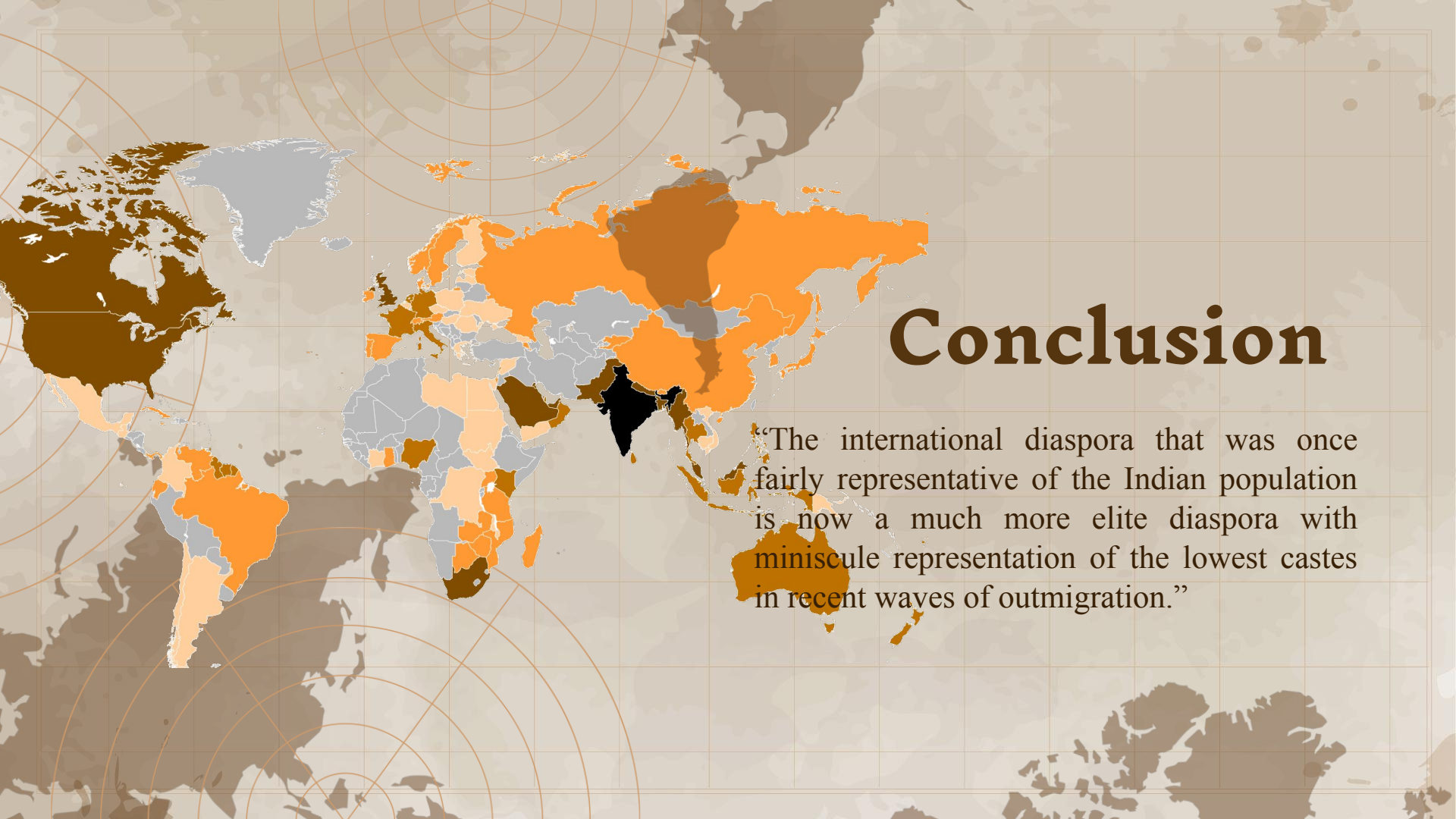
1973-74 &
1979

Two oil price hikes by the oil cartel led to windfall gains for oil companies, paving the way for massive infrastructure projects.

1975-2010

The population of the six Gulf states quadrupled from nearly 10 million to over 40 million.

- Oil took Indians to Gulf in large numbers in 1970s
- APOC, BAPCO, KOC and ARAMCO were some of the major oil companies that hired Indians
- For a while Hindus were banned from Qatar and Saudi Arabia, therefore most recruited Indians were mostly Muslims and Christians.
- From 1950-1970, over 34000 Indians were employed by oil companies.
- In the past decade, the locus of emigration to the Gulf shifted from the South the north, and the Bhojpuri-speaking tracts of eastern Uttar Pradesh and western Bihar



Conclusion

“The international diaspora that was once fairly representative of the Indian population is now a much more elite diaspora with miniscule representation of the lowest castes in recent waves of outmigration.”